God-Man or God's Man?

Church-Traditional Trinitarianism and Biblical Unitarian Christology

Jewish Agency, Wisdom Traditions, Early High Christology, the Holy Spirit, and Nicene Development

> **Governing contrast.** "God-Man" names the church-traditional claim that Jesus is God the Son incarnate. "God's Man" names the Biblical Unitarian claim that Jesus is the uniquely begotten, Spirit-anointed, crucified, resurrected, and exalted human Messiah through whom the one God reveals, saves, judges, and rules.

Abstract

This study asks whether the New Testament's exalted presentation of Jesus requires the church-traditional identification of him as the **God-Man**—God the Son incarnate and ontologically included within the one God of Israel—or is better explained through the Biblical Unitarian understanding of him as **God's Man**: the uniquely authorized human Messiah interpreted through Jewish categories of commissioned agency, personified Wisdom, divine image, messianic kingship, genuine human obedience, resurrection, and exaltation. It argues that Biblical Unitarian Christology offers substantial explanatory economy by preserving the New Testament's ordinary distinction between God and Jesus while affirming Jesus as God's unique Son, supreme agent, embodied Wisdom, risen Lord, mediator, and appointed judge.

The investigation treats the strongest Trinitarian evidence as genuine counterevidence: personal-preexistence texts, creation language, YHWH passages applied to Christ, direct divine titles, Thomas's confession, the worship of the Lamb, triadic formulas, personal language concerning the Spirit, and early Christian devotion. It also traces the development from New Testament Christology through the Apostolic Fathers, Logos theology, the Arian controversy, Nicaea, Constantinople, and Chalcedon; distinguishes Biblical Unitarianism from Arian, modalist, and adoptionist alternatives; and examines the implications for gospel proclamation, worship, discipleship, Christian identity, and interfaith dialogue.

> **Thesis.** The most economical synthesis of the total pattern is that the Father is the one God; Jesus is **God's Man**—the uniquely authorized human Messiah through whom God reveals, saves, judges, and rules; and the Holy Spirit is God's living presence and power active through the Messiah and among God's people. This conclusion remains qualified by the real pressure exerted by the New Testament's highest Christological and pneumatological texts.

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1. Introduction — God-Man or God's Man?

Few questions have shaped Christian theology more deeply than the identity of Jesus. Much of historic Christianity confesses him as the **God-Man**: the eternal Son, fully divine and fully human, distinct from the Father yet sharing the one divine essence. Biblical Unitarian Christology instead confesses him as **God's Man**—not merely a man, but God's uniquely begotten human Son, Messiah, supreme agent, image, mediator, resurrected Lord, and appointed judge—under the one God, the Father.

The central issue is not whether the New Testament exalts Jesus. It plainly does. Jesus is presented as Lord, Son of God, image of God, Wisdom of God, mediator, savior, judge, firstborn, heir, and ruler of the coming age. The real question is what this elevation means. Does the New Testament identify Jesus as the **God-Man**, eternally and ontologically included within the being of Israel's God, or as **God's Man**—the uniquely authorized human Messiah through whom God acts, reveals, judges, saves, and rules?

The earliest Christian evidence is complex enough to sustain a major scholarly debate. Dunn emphasized development and the importance of Jewish Wisdom and Adamic categories; Hurtado emphasized the remarkably early devotional place given to Jesus; and Bauckham argued that New Testament writers include Jesus within the unique divine identity of Israel's God.[1] [2] [3] These are not merely denominational slogans. They represent different attempts to account for the same data: explicit monotheistic confessions, Jesus' dependence upon God, cosmic language, YHWH texts, divine titles, resurrection exaltation, and worship.

This study argues that the Biblical Unitarian model has an important advantage in explanatory economy. It allows repeated statements that identify the Father as the one God and Jesus as the one sent by that God to retain their ordinary relational force. It takes seriously the biblical categories by which an authorized representative can bear divine words, authority, names, and functions without becoming the sender. It also interprets Wisdom and Word language within the Jewish literary world from which it emerged.

That conclusion is not established by pretending that every difficult text is easy. A responsible case must concede that several passages are naturally read as personal preexistence or direct divine identification. The argument is cumulative: the question is which model accounts for the largest range of texts, in their genres and historical settings, without repeatedly adding distinctions not stated by the texts themselves.

2. Method and Historical Cautions

2.1 Comparative Explanatory Power

Theological interpretation is not a mathematical proof in which one verse mechanically cancels another. Both Trinitarian and Biblical Unitarian models can construct coherent readings of much of the evidence. The responsible question is comparative: Which model best explains the total pattern? Which preserves the natural force of explicit relational statements? Which handles the highest Christological texts without reduction? Which requires fewer imported premises?

This method rejects two opposite shortcuts. It is not enough to quote "the Word was God" and assume that the later formula of one essence in three coequal persons has thereby been stated. It is equally inadequate to quote "the Father is greater than I" and refuse to engage incarnation or two-natures reasoning. Each model must be assessed in its strongest form.

2.2 First-Century Texts Must First Be Read in Their Jewish World

The New Testament arose within Jewish Scripture, Jewish monotheism, Jewish hopes for Messiah and kingdom, Jewish reflection on Wisdom and Word, and Jewish patterns of divine agency. This does not mean that every New Testament writer thought identically, nor that Jewish categories were static. Second Temple Judaism was diverse. Jewish texts could speak of personified Wisdom, the Logos, principal angels, exalted patriarchs, heavenly human figures, and a Son of Man associated with eschatological rule. Such diversity makes simple claims like "Jews could never imagine a preexistent Messiah" historically unsafe.[4] [5]

Yet diversity also requires conceptual precision. Preexistence, personification, divinity, heavenly status, participation in divine activity, and identity with the one God are not synonyms. A figure may be heavenly without being YHWH, called divine without sharing Nicene ontology, or invested with God's prerogatives without becoming the God who grants them.

2.3 Later Agency Law Must Be Used with Chronological Restraint

The rabbinic maxim that the legal status of a person's agent is like that of the principal is explicitly preserved in later rabbinic literature.[6] It is useful evidence for a mature Jewish legal concept, but the Babylonian Talmud is later than the New Testament. It should not be treated as a first-century handbook that Jesus and the evangelists consciously followed. The safer claim is that the later maxim formalizes a representative pattern already visible in Israel's Scriptures: the sender acts through the sent one; the agent's authorized act is attributed to the principal; and receiving or rejecting the messenger can count as receiving or rejecting the sender. Scholarship has long explored the relevance of this representative pattern to New Testament Christology, while also debating how far it can explain the evidence.[7] [8]

2.4 Doctrinal Development Is Evidence, Not an Automatic Disproof

The New Testament does not contain a systematic sentence defining God as three coequal persons sharing one essence. The mature pro-Nicene framework emerged through sustained controversy, interpretation, and conceptual refinement, especially between Nicaea in 325 and Constantinople in 381.[9] [10] That historical fact does not by itself disprove the doctrine. A later formulation may be judged a faithful inference from earlier texts. It does mean, however, that the historian should not silently assume the later metaphysical framework when asking what a first-century writer most naturally meant.

3. The One God and God's Man — The Human Messiah

3.1 The Identity Statements

The scriptural starting point is Israel's confession that YHWH is one (Deuteronomy 6:4). Jesus affirms this confession in Mark 12:29, and the approving scribe adds that God "is one" and that there is no other besides him. Within the New Testament, several formulations identify the one God specifically as the Father while distinguishing Jesus by messianic and mediatorial titles:

- John 17:3 addresses the Father as "the only true God" and distinguishes Jesus as the Messiah whom that God sent.
- First Corinthians 8:6 speaks of "one God, the Father," from whom are all things, and "one Lord, Jesus Christ," through whom are all things.
- First Timothy 2:5 identifies one God and one mediator between God and humanity, "the human Christ Jesus."
- Ephesians 4:6 speaks of "one God and Father of all."

These statements do not settle every question. Trinitarian interpreters argue that the Father may be called the one God without excluding the Son from the divine identity, just as Jesus may be called the one Lord without excluding the Father from lordship. First Corinthians 8:6 is therefore read by many as a christological reformulation of the Shema, distributing its divine titles across Father and Son.[3]

The Biblical Unitarian response begins with the sentence's grammar and relational structure. Paul explicitly identifies the one God as the Father and distinguishes Jesus as the one Lord through whom the Father's purposes are effected. "From" and "through" establish source and mediation. This reading does not make Jesus ordinary; it locates his unparalleled lordship under the God who appoints him.

3.2 The Apostolic Pattern in Acts

Acts repeatedly describes Jesus as a human being through whom God acts. Acts 2:22 calls him a man attested by God through mighty works that God did through him. God raises him, exalts him, and makes him both Lord and Messiah (Acts 2:24, 32-36). Acts 10:38 says God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and power, and that he healed because God was with him. Acts 17:31 says God will judge the world through a man whom he appointed and authenticated by resurrection.

These are not low claims. The risen Jesus receives universal lordship, pours out the Spirit, grants forgiveness, and will judge the world. Yet the verbs consistently distinguish the giver from the recipient: God anoints; Jesus is anointed. God raises; Jesus is raised. God exalts; Jesus is exalted. God appoints; Jesus is appointed. Biblical Unitarianism treats these as actual descriptions of Jesus' relation to God rather than as statements that apply only to one nature within a divine-human person.

3.3 Jesus Has a God

The New Testament repeatedly says that Jesus has a God. On the cross he cries, "My God, my God" (Mark 15:34). After resurrection he says, "my God and your God" (John 20:17). Paul speaks of "the God of our Lord Jesus Christ" (Ephesians 1:17), and 1 Peter 1:3 blesses "the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ." In Revelation 3:12 the exalted Jesus repeatedly says "my God."

Trinitarian theology explains this through incarnation and the distinction between Christ's divine and human natures. That account is internally coherent and became central to classical Christology. The exegetical question is whether the individual passages themselves signal that qualification. On a straightforward relational reading, Jesus is distinguished from the God whom he worships, obeys, and calls his God.

3.4 The Son's Final Subjection

First Corinthians 15:24–28 extends the hierarchy beyond Jesus' earthly ministry. At the consummation, the Son hands the kingdom to God the Father. God subjects all things to Christ, while God is explicitly excluded from what is subjected. Then the Son himself is subjected to the one who subjected all things to him, so that God may be all in all.

Trinitarian interpreters may describe this as the eternal order of divine relations or the mediatorial office of the incarnate Son. Biblical Unitarians see it as unusually direct evidence that even the exalted Son remains under the God who gave him authority.

4. Divine Agency — Representative Authority Without Ontological Identity

4.1 The Scriptural Grammar of Representation

The Hebrew Bible repeatedly attributes the sender's authority and speech to an authorized representative. Moses is made *elohim* to Pharaoh (Exodus 7:1), yet he does not become the God of Israel. Aaron serves as Moses' mouth, establishing a chain of representation from God to Moses to Aaron (Exodus 4:16).

The angel of YHWH provides an even stronger example. In Genesis 16, Genesis 22, Exodus 3, and Judges 2, the messenger can speak in the first person as God, exercise divine authority, and be narrated interchangeably with the sender. Exodus 23:20-21 explains that God's name is in the messenger. The messenger's speech is God's speech because the messenger is commissioned and name-bearing; the narrative can therefore move between agent and principal without erasing their distinction.

Kings, judges, priests, and prophets supply related patterns. Psalm 45 can address a royal figure with *elohim* language while immediately speaking of "God, your God," who anoints him. Solomon sits on the "throne of YHWH" (1 Chronicles 29:23) without becoming YHWH. Human judges may bear divine terminology; prophets speak God's words; rulers administer divine judgment; and deliverers can be called saviors because God saves through them.

The lexical and conceptual lesson is limited but important: divine titles, divine functions, and first-person divine speech do not automatically establish ontological identity. Context must determine whether the language expresses identity, representation, participation, or delegated authority.

4.2 The Legal Maxim and Its Proper Use

Kiddushin 41b formulates the later legal principle that the status of an authorized agent is like that of the person who sent the agent.[6] The Jewish Encyclopedia summarizes the same principle in legal terms: an agent acting within the commission can bind the principal.[11] The concept does not mean that agent and principal are numerically the same person. It means that the authorized act of the representative counts as the act of the sender.

Applied cautiously, this gives a useful analogy for the New Testament. It should not be inflated into a complete Christology, and it should not be used to deny everything distinctive about Jesus. It clarifies how representation can be so complete that the agent bears the sender's authority while remaining personally distinct.

4.3 Jesus as the Sent One

The Gospel of John is structured around the Father sending the Son. Jesus says that his food is to do the will of the one who sent him (John 4:34); that the Son can do nothing from himself (5:19); that judgment has been given to him (5:22, 27); that he seeks not his own will but the will of the sender (5:30); that his teaching is not his own (7:16); that he speaks what the Father taught him (8:28); and that the Father commanded what he should say (12:49). In John 14:10, the words are not independent words and the works are the Father's works in him.

The same logic extends through chains of representation. Whoever receives Jesus' disciples receives Jesus, and whoever receives Jesus receives the one who sent him (Matthew 10:40; John 13:20). Rejecting the disciples counts as rejecting Jesus and ultimately the sender (Luke 10:16). No one infers that the disciples are ontologically identical with Jesus. The sayings demonstrate how strongly biblical language can identify a representative with the represented party at the level of reception, authority, and action.

4.4 Seeing the Father in Jesus

John 12:44-45 links believing in Jesus with believing in the one who sent him, and seeing Jesus with seeing the sender. John 14:9 therefore need not mean that Jesus is the Father or that the Father and Son are numerically one being. The immediate explanation is revelatory and participatory: the Father dwells in Jesus, speaks through him, and performs works through him.

Agency accounts for both halves of Johannine Christology. Jesus can reveal God with unparalleled completeness because he is God's unique Son and definitive agent; yet his teaching, authority, works, judgment, and mission are repeatedly received from another. The strength of the model is that representation presupposes distinction while permitting exceptionally high language.

Its limitation must also be stated. Some New Testament passages appear to go beyond ordinary agency by placing Jesus in creation, applying YHWH texts to him, and giving him a unique place in worship. Agency is therefore a major interpretive category, not a slogan that makes every problem disappear.

5. Wisdom and Word — From Divine Purpose to the Historical Jesus

5.1 Personified Wisdom in Early Jewish Texts

Proverbs 8 portrays Wisdom as a woman calling humanity to life and as present before or during God's creation. The poetry is vivid and has generated interpretations ranging from literary personification to heavenly hypostasis.[12] Sirach 24 intensifies the imagery: Wisdom comes from the mouth of the Most High, dwells in heaven, traverses creation, and is commanded by the Creator to make her dwelling in Israel; the chapter then identifies this Wisdom with Torah.[13] Wisdom of Solomon 7 describes Wisdom as a pure emanation of divine glory, a reflection of eternal light, a mirror of God's activity, and an image of divine goodness.[14]

These texts establish a crucial possibility. Jewish monotheistic discourse could use personal, cosmic, radiant, image-bearing, and mediatorial language for God's Wisdom without offering the later Nicene formula. Scholars continue to debate whether particular texts present mere personification, a quasi-personal hypostasis, or something more substantial.[15] The debate itself warns against assuming that elevated language carries only one metaphysical meaning.

5.2 Wisdom Becomes Historically Localized

Sirach 24 is especially instructive because cosmic Wisdom becomes concretely localized in Israel's Torah. The text does not require a Torah scroll to have lived consciously in heaven as a woman. Poetic and theological language moves from God's eternal Wisdom to a historical embodiment of that Wisdom in covenantal revelation.

This supplies an analogy, not a proof, for New Testament Christology. God's eternal Wisdom, Word, purpose, and self-revelation can become historically visible in Jesus. What is eternally true of God's Wisdom may be predicated of the Messiah who embodies it. The historical Jesus is not thereby reduced to a metaphor; he becomes the definitive personal realization of God's revelatory purpose.

5.3 Philo and the Range of Mediatorial Language

Philo of Alexandria uses remarkably elevated language for the Logos: image, firstborn, cosmic mediator, and instrument of divine ordering. His terminology stands within a Hellenistic Jewish attempt to speak of God's transcendence and activity in the world. Yet the exact personal status of Philo's Logos is debated, and direct dependence of New Testament Christology upon Philo cannot simply be assumed.[16] [17]

Philo is therefore most useful as evidence of conceptual range. Jewish writers could speak of divine mediation in language that sounds personal and exalted while continuing to distinguish the supreme God from the mediating reality.

5.4 Proverbs 8:22 — "Created," "Possessed," or "Brought Forth"?

Proverbs 8:22 became one of the most consequential verses in the history of Christology. The Hebrew verb *qanah* has a semantic range that can include acquiring or possessing, while the ancient Greek Septuagint rendered the clause with *ektisen*, "created." The literary speaker remains personified Wisdom, but once Christian interpreters identified that Wisdom directly with the preexistent Son, the translation became doctrinally explosive.[12]

Arian interpreters could reason that if Wisdom is the Son and Wisdom says that the Lord created her, then the Son is the first and greatest creature rather than coeternal God. Pro-Nicene interpreters rejected that conclusion. Athanasius treated the language as proverbial and applied it to the Son's incarnational or economic role rather than to the divine essence; other interpreters favored renderings such as "possessed" or understood the passage in terms of eternal generation.[23]

The verse does not settle the debate by itself. "Possessed" can fit the claim that God eternally possesses his Wisdom, while "created" can support an Arian reading if Wisdom is treated as a literal heavenly person. A Biblical Unitarian reading questions the shared premise. If the poem is a literary personification of God's own Wisdom, its language need not describe the origin of a second conscious being at all. The controversy therefore illustrates how a prior decision about personification can control the metaphysical conclusion drawn from the text.

5.5 Wisdom in Early Christian Interpretation

The early church's use of Wisdom language shows both continuity and development. Origen identified the Son with God's eternal Wisdom and used that identification to explain why the Father was never without his Word or Wisdom.[27] Arius and Athanasius likewise treated Proverbs 8 as christologically relevant, although they drew opposing conclusions from its language. The dispute was not over whether Wisdom imagery mattered, but over whether it described a created mediator, an eternally generated Son, an incarnational economy, or poetic personification.

This history is important for two reasons. First, it confirms that Wisdom traditions were not a marginal background but a major bridge between biblical language and later ontological Christology. Second, it warns against assuming that the New Testament's Wisdom language already contains the fully developed conclusions later theologians drew from it. Historical influence and original semantic content are related questions, but they are not identical.

5.6 The Word Becomes Flesh

John 1 begins with "the Word," not explicitly with "Jesus" or "the Son." In Israel's Scriptures, God's word creates, reveals, judges, and accomplishes God's purpose (Genesis 1; Psalm 33:6; Isaiah 55:10-11). Wisdom traditions add language of presence with God, participation in creation, radiance, and descent into history.

The Trinitarian reading identifies the Logos as the personally preexistent Son: distinct from God in relation, yet divine in identity, and incarnate in Jesus. This reading naturally connects "the Word was with God," "the Word was God," creation through the Word, and the Word's becoming flesh.

The Biblical Unitarian reading begins with God's own self-expression rather than a second conscious person. The Word is "with" God as God's Wisdom, purpose, and expressive activity; it is "God" because it is God's own revelatory and creative self-expression. Verse 14 marks the decisive personal embodiment: the Word becomes flesh in the human Messiah.

Wisdom background makes this reading historically plausible, but it does not by itself decide the issue. The prologue's personal grammar, creation language, and use of *theos* give the Trinitarian reading genuine force. Conversely, the shift from "Word" to the historical Son and the continuing distinction between Jesus and his God give the embodiment reading a coherent context.

5.7 Kinds of Preexistence

Biblical language can describe realities as existing with God before their historical appearance. Believers are chosen in Christ before the foundation of the world (Ephesians 1:4); grace is given before the ages (2 Timothy 1:9); and Christ is foreknown before the foundation of the world and manifested later (1 Peter 1:20). This makes ideal, prophetic, or foreordained preexistence a real biblical category.

It does not follow that every preexistence statement is ideal. John 8:58 and John 17:5 naturally invite a personal-preexistence reading. The interpreter must ask passage by passage whether the author speaks of a conscious heavenly life, personified divine purpose, foreordination, proleptic glory, or some combination. A strong Biblical Unitarian account should not deny the language of preexistence; it should specify what kind of preexistence each text is most likely to intend.

6. Major Christological Texts — Exegesis and Counterevidence

6.1 John 1:1–18

John's prologue is foundational because it combines distinction, divinity, creation, revelation, and embodiment. "The Word was with God" distinguishes the Logos from the God with whom it was; "the Word was God" gives the Logos divine predication; all things come into being through it; and the Word becomes flesh.

A Trinitarian reading sees the conceptual pattern that later theology would articulate more precisely: the Word is personally distinguishable from the Father and yet shares the divine identity. The incarnation is therefore the assumption of human nature by the eternal Son.

A Biblical Unitarian reading emphasizes that the prologue initially names God's Word, not an already identified person called Jesus. The language can be read through Jewish speech and Wisdom traditions in which God's own expression is conceptually distinguished, personified, and active. On this reading, verse 14 does not describe a heavenly person changing location; it describes God's eternal self-expression becoming embodied in a human life.

John 1:18 adds a genuine textual difficulty. Ancient witnesses vary between forms meaning "unique God" and "unique Son," and the reading with *theos* has strong early support.[18] Even if "unique God" is original, however, one must still ask how John uses divine predication. The verse does not independently define a tri-personal divine essence. At the same time, it is too strong to be dismissed as an insignificant variant.

The most balanced judgment is that John 1 strongly supports high Logos Christology and is compatible with personal preexistence. Wisdom embodiment remains a historically grounded alternative, but it carries the responsibility of explaining the prologue's personal and creative language in full.

6.2 John 8:58 and John 17:5

John 8:58 contrasts Abraham's coming into existence with Jesus' declaration, "I am." The Greek phrase *ego eimi* is not, by itself, an exclusive divine name; ordinary speakers can use it for self-identification. Yet the temporal contrast and dramatic setting make a claim to existence before Abraham a natural reading. A Trinitarian interpretation may also hear an echo of divine self-identification.

Biblical Unitarian proposals include messianic priority in God's plan, prophetic prolepsis, or an identity grounded in the promised Messiah who precedes Abraham in divine purpose. These proposals are possible within biblical patterns of foreordination, but they are less immediately obvious than personal preexistence. John 8:58 should therefore be treated as substantial counterevidence, not dissolved by a lexical observation about *ego eimi*.

John 17:5 is still more direct: Jesus asks the Father for the glory he had with the Father before the world existed. Scripture can speak proleptically of prepared glory and realities held in God's purpose, but "with you" makes a personal reading straightforward. The Unitarian interpretation can appeal to the certainty of divine foreordination, yet the verse remains one of the strongest texts against a non-personal-preexistence model.

6.3 John 10:30–36 and John 20:28

"I and the Father are one" in John 10:30 uses the neuter *hen*, naturally expressing unity rather than personal identity. John 17 uses parallel language for the desired unity of believers. The unity of Father and Son is unique in degree and mission, but the grammatical form alone does not define one essence.

The immediate controversy is also important. Jesus responds to the accusation of making himself God by citing Psalm 82, where subordinate figures receive divine terminology, and he restates his claim as "I am God's Son." A representative reading sees this as direct evidence that divinely authorized figures can bear god-language without becoming the supreme God.

Thomas's confession in John 20:28, "My Lord and my God," is more difficult. The most natural grammar addresses both titles to Jesus. Attempts to divide the words between Jesus and the Father are unpersuasive. A Biblical Unitarian reading should accept the address and interpret it within John's agency and revelation themes: Thomas recognizes the risen Jesus as the climactic manifestation of God and as the bearer of divine authority. This interpretation is supported by Jesus' statement only verses earlier, "my God and your God," and by the evangelist's purpose statement that readers believe Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God (20:31).

The Trinitarian reading remains strong: the Gospel that begins with divine Logos language culminates in an apostolic confession of Jesus as God. The Unitarian reply is coherent only if divine predication can be representational or royal, not if the title is grammatically evaded.

6.4 The Synoptic Gospels and Acts

The Synoptic Gospels ordinarily present Jesus in relation to God. He prays, obeys, receives the Spirit, distinguishes his will from God's in Gethsemane, and confesses limited knowledge of the final hour (Mark 13:32). He affirms the Shema, calls the Father Lord of heaven and earth, and directs worship toward God.

Several acts often treated as direct proof of deity are framed in terms of authority. In Mark 2, Jesus forgives sins and concludes that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive. Matthew's parallel reports the crowd glorifying God for giving such authority to human beings. John 20:23 extends forgiveness-authority to disciples. The issue is not whether forgiveness ultimately belongs to God, but whether God may exercise it through an authorized agent.

Daniel 7 and Psalm 110 similarly portray exaltation beside God. The humanlike figure receives dominion from the Ancient of Days; the Davidic lord is invited to sit at YHWH's right hand. These texts support extraordinary heavenly authority while retaining a distinction between the enthroned agent and the God who enthrones him.

Matthew 28:18 says all authority in heaven and earth has been given to Jesus. The triadic baptismal formula in verse 19 is theologically weighty, but association of Father, Son, and Spirit does not by itself define their ontology. Luke 1:35 explains Jesus' sonship through the Spirit's action and the miraculous conception: "therefore" the child will be called Son of God. None of these observations refutes Trinitarianism, but the Synoptic narrative does not explicitly state the later two-natures ontology used to harmonize dependence and deity.

6.5 First Corinthians 8:6

First Corinthians 8:6 is one of the strongest texts on both sides. Paul says that for believers there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom believers exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom believers exist.

The divine-identity reading argues that Paul has reformulated the Shema by assigning "God" to the Father and "Lord" to Jesus. Since *kyrios* commonly renders the divine name in the Greek Scriptures, Jesus is included in Israel's unique divine identity. The verse's creation language strengthens that interpretation.[3]

The Biblical Unitarian reading observes that Paul explicitly identifies the one God as the Father and then distinguishes Jesus as the one Lord. The prepositions preserve order: all things are ultimately "from" God and "through" Christ. Agency and messianic lordship can explain why the exalted Messiah participates in divine action without becoming the God who is its source.

Neither reading should be trivialized. The verse places Jesus at the center of creation and redeemed existence; it also preserves a grammatical distinction between the one God and the one Lord. Any adequate model must explain both.

6.6 Philippians 2:5–11

Philippians 2 can be read as a descent-and-ascent narrative of a preexistent divine person: Christ exists in God's form, does not exploit equality, empties himself, takes servant form, becomes human, dies, and is exalted. This reading is ancient, coherent, and naturally fits several phrases.

An Adamic and messianic reading sees Jesus as the true image-bearing human who, unlike Adam, refuses grasping or exploitation. He assumes the servant's path, obeys unto death, and is therefore exalted. The disputed noun *harpagmos* does not yield a simple slogan; it concerns the way Christ relates to equality with God, whether as something not seized, not exploited, or not used for advantage. Scholarly debate continues over Adamic, preexistence, angelic, and other backgrounds.[19]

The passage's explicit logic deserves weight. God exalts Jesus and gives him the name above every name; universal confession of Jesus as Lord is "to the glory of God the Father." Isaiah 45's universal bowing language is applied to Jesus, which constitutes exceptionally high Christology. Yet the honor is given by God and terminates in God's glory.

The fairest conclusion is that Philippians 2 strongly supports either personal preexistence or an extraordinarily high Adamic-messianic Christology. It does not, by itself, spell out coequal persons sharing one essence.

6.7 Colossians 1:15–20

Colossians calls Christ the image of the invisible God, firstborn of all creation, the one in or through whom all things were created, the one before all things, the head of the body, the firstborn from the dead, and the one in whom divine fullness dwells.

An exclusively new-creation interpretation is too narrow. The passage refers to heaven and earth, visible and invisible realities, thrones, dominions, rulers, and authorities. The cosmic scope is genuine. A strong Biblical Unitarian reading should concede this rather than reduce the text to ecclesiology.

Several Jewish categories remain relevant. "Image" is representational; "firstborn" can denote royal supremacy and inheritance, as in Psalm 89:27; and Wisdom traditions provide language for God's cosmic ordering. Sean McDonough argues that messianic dominion is at least as important as Wisdom for Colossians and that "firstborn" fits a Davidic-royal context.[20]

The central question is whether the conscious human Jesus personally performed the act of Genesis creation, or whether the cosmic role of God's Wisdom, Word, image, purpose, and messianic dominion is christologically predicated of the risen Messiah. The latter is possible within Jewish theological language, but the repeated personal pronouns and cosmic scope make personal preexistence a powerful reading. Colossians 1 remains major counterevidence that a responsible Unitarian synthesis must carry rather than minimize.

6.8 Hebrews 1

Hebrews presents the Son as God's climactic revelation, appointed heir, radiance of glory, exact representation, agent of creation, sustainer, purified high priest, and enthroned ruler. The language of radiance and image closely resembles Wisdom of Solomon 7, showing that Jewish Wisdom vocabulary belongs in the interpretive field.[14]

The chapter also emphasizes appointment, inheritance, anointing, and enthronement. Psalm 45 addresses the royal Son as "God" while immediately saying, "God, your God, has anointed you." This is compatible with royal divine predication under the God who anoints.

Hebrews 1:10–12 is harder. The author applies to the Son language from Psalm 102 about the Lord who founded the earth and stretched out the heavens. Most readers naturally understand the quotation as addressed to the Son. Sean McDonough treats Hebrews as major evidence for Christ's agency in creation and connects that agency to messianic status.[21]

Wisdom embodiment, scriptural transfer to the supreme Messiah, and representative identity offer possible Unitarian explanations. Nevertheless, Hebrews 1:10–12 is among the strongest creator-Christology objections to a non-personal-preexistence view. Intellectual honesty requires saying so plainly.

6.9 Romans 9:5, Titus 2:13, and 2 Peter 1:1

Several passages may directly call Jesus *theos*. Romans 9:5 depends partly on punctuation and syntactical judgment; a christological reading is grammatically possible and widely defended. Titus 2:13 and 2 Peter 1:1 naturally permit, and may favor, taking "God and Savior" as a single reference to Jesus.

A weak Unitarian strategy declares such readings impossible. A stronger strategy concedes the syntax and asks what divine predication means within the wider scriptural environment. Moses, royal figures, judges, and God's supreme representative can receive divine terminology without being identified as the one God. Yet repeated use of *theos* for Jesus, if accepted, adds cumulative weight to the Trinitarian case. The title cannot simply be neutralized by pointing to one Old Testament analogy.

6.10 Mark 10:18, Mark 13:32, Luke 1:35, and Matthew 28

Mark 10:18 records Jesus asking, "Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone." A Trinitarian reading may hear a rhetorical invitation to recognize Jesus' deeper identity, and that interpretation is possible. On the surface, however, the saying distinguishes Jesus from the one whom he identifies as God. Mark 13:32 presents an even sharper distinction: the Son does not know the day or hour known by the Father. Classical Christology accounts for this through the limits of Christ's human knowledge, but the verse itself does not state a two-consciousness or two-natures qualification.

Luke 1:35 explains Jesus' sonship through miraculous conception: the Spirit comes upon Mary, the power of the Most High overshadows her, and "therefore" the child is called Son of God. The immediate narrative does not describe an eternally conscious Son entering the womb. Matthew 28:18–20, by contrast, combines conferred universal authority with the triadic baptismal formula. The association of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit is theologically weighty, yet association and shared liturgical placement do not by themselves define a single essence or coequal personhood.

6.11 Revelation — The Lamb, the Throne, and "My God"

Revelation gives the Lamb one of the highest roles in the New Testament. He receives cosmic praise, opens the divine scroll, executes judgment, shares royal rule, and stands at the center of the renewed creation. The density of this imagery is a major part of the Trinitarian cumulative case, since Jesus occupies a devotional and sovereign place no ordinary prophet occupies.

The book also preserves distinction. The Lamb is repeatedly distinguished from the One seated on the throne, and the exalted Jesus says "my God" four times in Revelation 3:12. These words occur after resurrection and exaltation, not merely during earthly humiliation. A Biblical Unitarian reading therefore understands the Lamb's glory as the maximum elevation of God's appointed Messiah; a Trinitarian reading understands the shared praise and throne as evidence that the Lamb participates in the divine identity. Any adequate account must preserve both the extraordinary honor and the continuing relational distinction.

6.12 Son of God, Lord, Savior, and Mediator

The title "Son of God" does not lexically mean "God the Son, the second person of a triune essence." Israel, the Davidic king, Adam, and the righteous can be called God's son or children. Jesus' sonship is unique, but its biblical field includes royal election, miraculous conception, covenant, obedience, resurrection, and messianic enthronement.

Likewise, *kyrios* can render the divine name, but it can also mean master, ruler, or lord. Acts 2:36 says that God made Jesus both Lord and Messiah, placing his lordship within exaltation. "Savior" can identify God as the ultimate source of deliverance and Jesus as the appointed agent through whom that deliverance is accomplished. First Timothy 2:5 summarizes the relational pattern: there is one God and one mediator between God and humanity, the human Messiah Jesus. The titles are therefore genuinely exalted, but their ontological force must be determined from context rather than assumed from the titles alone.

7. The Holy Spirit — Divine Presence, Power, and Triadic Evidence

7.1 The Spirit as God's Active Presence and Power

Biblical language often presents the Spirit as God in action: God's breath, life-giving power, prophetic inspiration, holy presence, and eschatological gift. The Spirit is poured out, given, received, distributed, and placed upon people. Jesus is conceived by the Spirit, anointed with the Spirit, led by the Spirit, and empowered by the Spirit. Believers become temples because God dwells in them by his Spirit.

Biblical Unitarian theology therefore commonly understands the Holy Spirit not as a third coequal person alongside the Father and Son, but as God's own active presence and power. This reading does not deny the reality of the Spirit. It identifies the Spirit with God's immanent action: the one God creates, reveals, sanctifies, empowers, and dwells among his people by his Spirit.

7.2 Personal Language and the Trinitarian Counterargument

The New Testament also uses strikingly personal language. The Spirit speaks, sends, teaches, guides, bears witness, distributes gifts, can be grieved, and intercedes. Acts 5:3-4 closely associates lying to the Holy Spirit with lying to God. Trinitarian theology treats this cumulative pattern as evidence that the Spirit is not merely an impersonal force but a distinct divine person.

A Biblical Unitarian response notes that Scripture frequently personifies divine attributes and powers, and that the Spirit may speak because God speaks through his Spirit. Yet the personal language should not be dismissed. A responsible nontrinitarian account must explain why God's presence is narrated with such agency and relational vividness, just as a Trinitarian account must explain why the Spirit is so often described as something God gives, pours out, or places upon others.

7.3 Triadic Formulas

Matthew 28:19 places Father, Son, and Holy Spirit together in baptism, while 2 Corinthians 13:14 joins the grace of Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit in blessing. Other passages coordinate God, Christ, and Spirit in salvation, gifts, mission, and worship. These formulas supplied important raw material for later Trinitarian doctrine.

They do not, by themselves, state that the three are coequal persons sharing one essence. Triadic coordination can identify three distinguishable realities or agents within one saving economy without specifying their ontology. Nevertheless, the formulas make any theology that treats the Spirit as a marginal afterthought inadequate.

7.4 From New Testament Pneumatology to Constantinople

The first centuries of Christian controversy concentrated primarily on the relation of the Son to the Father. Tertullian articulated an early Latin formula of one substance and three persons, but even then the later consensus was not yet complete.[26] The Council of Constantinople in 381 confessed the Holy Spirit as "Lord and giver of life," proceeding from the Father and worshiped and glorified with the Father and Son.[28] This was a decisive stage in the mature doctrine of one God in three persons.[9] [10]

The historical point is not that the Spirit was invented in 381. The Spirit pervades the biblical narrative and early Christian life. The point is that the ontological definition of the Spirit's relation to Father and Son emerged through doctrinal development. Biblical Unitarians regard that definition as an unnecessary metaphysical extension; Trinitarians regard it as the church's faithful synthesis of the scriptural pattern.

7.5 A Biblical Unitarian Synthesis

Within a Biblical Unitarian framework, the confession may be summarized as one God, the Father; one Lord Messiah, Jesus; and one Holy Spirit, the living presence and power of God active through the Messiah and among God's people. This formulation preserves the triadic shape of salvation while declining to define the Spirit as a third center of consciousness within one divine essence. Its strength is continuity with the Bible's language of God giving and pouring out the Spirit; its burden is to account fully for the Spirit's personal and relational language.

8. Worship and Divine Prerogatives — Honor, Authority, and YHWH Texts

8.1 The Reality of Early Devotion

The earliest Christian movement gave Jesus an extraordinary place in religious life. Believers invoked his name, confessed him as Lord, baptized with reference to him, celebrated the Lord's Supper around him, appealed to him, expected his return, and included him in hymnic and liturgical patterns. Hurtado's major historical work emphasizes how early and distinctive this devotion was.[2]

Any account in which Jesus remained an insignificant teacher until Constantine made him divine is historically indefensible. High Christology did not begin at Nicaea. The fourth-century councils defined how Christ's relation to God should be understood; they did not invent Christian devotion to Jesus.

8.2 Does Worship Prove Ontological Deity?

The Greek verb *proskyneo* can denote worship of God, but it can also describe homage, prostration, or reverence before human rulers and superiors. The action's meaning depends on its object, setting, and narrative function. Therefore, a bare occurrence of *proskyneo* is not a complete ontological argument.

The larger devotional pattern is more significant than one verb. Jesus receives cosmic praise in Revelation, is invoked in early Christian practice, and occupies a place no ordinary prophet occupies. Trinitarian interpreters reasonably argue that this is best explained by inclusion in the divine identity.

Biblical Unitarians answer that God commands honor for the ruler he appoints. Philippians 2 frames universal confession as the result of God's exaltation and as glory to the Father. Revelation distinguishes the Lamb from the One seated on the throne even while both receive praise; Revelation 3:12 preserves Jesus' reference to "my God." Devotion may therefore be mediated through God's supreme representative.

The evidence establishes extraordinary devotion beyond dispute. Whether it establishes coequal ontology remains the interpretive question.

8.3 Forgiveness, Judgment, Salvation, and Life

A common argument has the form: God alone forgives, judges, saves, gives life, or receives worship; Jesus performs these acts; therefore Jesus is God. The hidden premise is that a divine prerogative cannot be delegated.

Scripture repeatedly depicts delegated divine activity. Judges save Israel under God's commission; priests mediate forgiveness; prophets speak divine words; kings execute God's judgment; apostles forgive or retain sins; and agents bear the sender's name. John 5 explicitly says the Father gives the Son authority to judge and grants the Son to have life in himself. Acts 17 says God judges through the man he appointed. Matthew 28 says universal authority is given to Jesus.

Delegation does not make the act unreal. If God judges through Jesus, Jesus truly judges. The question is whether the exercise of a divine function proves that the agent is ontologically the source of the function. The biblical pattern shows that the inference is not automatic.

8.4 YHWH Texts Applied to Jesus

New Testament writers apply to Jesus passages originally referring to YHWH. This is among the strongest arguments for divine identity. It occurs in contexts of preparing the Lord's way, calling on the Lord's name, universal bowing, creator language, and eschatological salvation.

A representational response appeals to scriptural patterns of name-bearing, royal enthronement, and authorized presence. Exodus 23 depicts an angel bearing God's name; the Davidic king sits on YHWH's throne; God's acts can be narrated through agents. If the Messiah is God's final and supreme representative, divine texts may be reapplied to him because God acts and is encountered through him.

That response is conceptually possible, but it should not be treated as effortless. The density and importance of the transfers may indicate more than ordinary agency. The debate is cumulative: Trinitarians see inclusion in the divine identity; Unitarians see the maximum extension of biblical representation under the one God.

9. God's Man and the Restoration of Humanity — Adam Christology and Redemption

9.1 Genuine Obedience, Temptation, Faith, and Suffering

The New Testament does not merely affirm that Jesus possesses a human body. It portrays a genuinely human life of growth, dependence, prayer, temptation, faith, obedience, suffering, and death. Jesus grows in wisdom, receives the Spirit, prays for help, distinguishes his will from God's in Gethsemane, learns obedience through suffering, and entrusts himself to the One who can save him from death.

Classical Christology preserves this material through the doctrine that the eternal Son assumed a complete human nature. Biblical Unitarianism reads it more directly: the subject who obeys, trusts, suffers, and dies is God's human Son. His faithfulness is not a temporary performance by an omniscient divine consciousness but the real achievement of a Spirit-anointed human being.

9.2 The Second Adam and Faithful Israelite

Paul's Adam-Christ pattern gives theological depth to Jesus' humanity. Romans 5 contrasts the disobedience of one man with the obedience of another. First Corinthians 15 says that death came through a man and resurrection likewise comes through a man; Christ is the last Adam and the firstfruits of renewed humanity. Philippians 2 can also be heard within this image-bearing and Adamic field: Jesus refuses grasping, takes the servant's path, obeys unto death, and is therefore exalted.

Jesus also fulfills Israel's vocation. He is the faithful Son, servant, prophet, priest, and Davidic king through whom God's covenant purposes reach their goal. His humanity is therefore not an obstacle that must be overcome before he can save. It is the sphere in which humanity's failed vocation is faithfully completed.

9.3 Resurrection as Vindication and Exaltation

The resurrection is God's decisive vindication of Jesus. God overturns the human verdict, raises the crucified Messiah, makes him firstfruits of the coming resurrection, seats him at the divine right hand, and appoints him as judge and ruler. In Acts, exaltation is described as something God actually does to Jesus: God glorifies him, makes him Lord and Messiah, and grants universal authority.

Incarnation theology often understands this as the incarnate Son's return to, or public manifestation of, eternal glory. Biblical Unitarianism treats the language as a real transition in the historical Messiah's status. The obedient human Son becomes the exalted Lord of the new creation because God raises and enthrones him.

9.4 Mediation, Atonement, and Salvation Through a Human Representative

First Timothy 2:5 identifies the mediator between God and humanity as "the human Messiah Jesus." Hebrews presents a high priest who shares human weakness, suffers, learns obedience, and represents humanity before God. Second Corinthians 5:19 says that God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself: God is the ultimate reconciler, Christ is the one in and through whom reconciliation occurs, and humanity is the object of reconciliation.

Trinitarian soteriology often argues that only one who is truly divine can unite humanity to God or give saving efficacy to the atonement. The Biblical Unitarian response is that the value of Jesus' death rests on God's appointment, Jesus' sinless obedience, and his representative role as Messiah and second Adam. God is free to save through the human being he has authorized. The disagreement is not over whether salvation is divine action, but over whether the agent of that action must be ontologically identical with God.

9.5 The Mission and Gospel of Jesus

Jesus' mission is to reveal the Father, announce and inaugurate God's kingdom, call people to repentance and covenant faithfulness, embody divine compassion and righteousness, surrender his life, be vindicated by resurrection, gather God's renewed people, mediate the new covenant, and ultimately bring creation under God's rule.

The apostolic gospel is therefore narrative before it is metaphysical. God sends Jesus; Jesus proclaims the kingdom and obeys unto death; God raises and exalts him; the risen Messiah grants forgiveness, pours out the Spirit, gathers the nations, and will return to judge and renew the world. Salvation is from the Father, through the Son, by the Spirit. This is a high Christology because God has made the human Messiah central to creation's redemption.

10. From Early Christology to Creed — Nicaea, Constantinople, and Chalcedon

10.1 Early Devotion and the Limits of the "Constantine Invented It" Narrative

The earliest Christian movement gave Jesus a remarkably elevated place in confession, baptism, prayer, meals, hymnic material, eschatological expectation, and communal identity. This devotion is visible before the fourth century and cannot be explained by a story in which an insignificant Galilean teacher was suddenly declared divine by imperial decree.[2] The councils did not create Christian devotion to Jesus; they attempted to define what that devotion implied about his relation to the one God.

At the same time, early devotion did not arrive with a universally agreed metaphysical grammar. Christians could call Jesus Lord, invoke him, identify him with Word or Wisdom, and speak of him as divine while still disagreeing about generation, subordination, personhood, essence, and the relation of the human and divine.

10.2 Ignatius and Early God-Language for Jesus

Ignatius of Antioch, writing in the early second century, uses striking language for Jesus, including references commonly translated as "our God, Jesus Christ" and descriptions of one physician who is both flesh and spirit, made and not made, God in flesh.[24] His letters also distinguish the Father and Jesus and emphasize that Jesus truly suffered, countering docetic tendencies.

Ignatius therefore supplies important evidence that explicit God-language for Jesus predates Nicaea. He does not, however, present the later technical formula of one essence in three coequal persons or the Chalcedonian account of two natures. His witness demonstrates early high Christology while also illustrating the distance between devotional predication and mature conciliar ontology.

10.3 Justin, Irenaeus, Tertullian, and Origen

Justin Martyr develops a Logos Christology in which the preexistent Christ is the divine Word who appears in biblical theophanies and is distinguishable from the transcendent Father. He can call this figure another or second God while still insisting that the Father is the ultimate source.[25] Justin's model is elevated but ordered and subordinate rather than simply identical with later Nicene coequality.

Irenaeus emphasizes one Creator God acting through the Son and Spirit, his "two hands," and interprets salvation through recapitulation: Christ reverses Adam's failure and restores humanity. Tertullian supplies influential Latin vocabulary—one substance and three persons—while arguing against modalism and preserving an ordered relation among Father, Son, and Spirit.[26] Origen develops the eternal generation of the Son and identifies the Son with God's Wisdom, yet continues to speak of the Father as the fountainhead and to use hierarchical language.[27] Historical surveys therefore find both real continuity with later doctrine and significant differences from its mature form.[9] [31]

10.4 Arius and the Fourth-Century Crisis

Arius did not teach modern Biblical Unitarianism. He affirmed a personally preexistent heavenly Son through whom God created, but denied that the Son was unbegotten, coeternal, or of the same essence as the Father. His position protected the unique ultimacy of the Father by placing the Son on the created side of the Creator-creature distinction, however exalted the Son might be.[30]

The controversy forced the church to ask whether worship and salvation through Christ were coherent if the Son were a creature. Athanasius argued that only the uncreated Son could truly reveal God and communicate divine life. Proverbs 8:22, creation texts, divine titles, and the language of generation became central exegetical battlegrounds.[23]

10.5 Nicaea and the Pro-Nicene Settlement

The Council of Nicaea in 325 confessed the Son as "God from God," "true God from true God," "begotten, not made," and *homoousios*—of one essence—with the Father.[22] The wording was designed to exclude the claim that the Son is a creature or belongs to a lesser order of being.

Nicaea did not immediately settle the issue. The meaning and acceptability of *homoousios* were contested for decades, with competing homoian, homoiousian, and pro-Nicene proposals. Athanasius and the Cappadocian theologians helped clarify the distinction between one divine *ousia* and three *hypostases*. The mature pro-Nicene position was the product of sustained controversy rather than the mere publication of a single creed.[10] [30]

10.6 Constantinople, Chalcedon, and the Two-Natures Framework

The Council of Constantinople in 381 reinforced the Nicene confession and gave fuller expression to the deity of the Holy Spirit.[28] The doctrine now took the recognizable form of one Godhead in irreducible Father, Son, and Spirit. The Council of Chalcedon in 451 addressed a different but related question: how the one Christ can be fully divine and fully human. Its definition confessed one and the same Son in two natures, without confusion, change, division, or separation.[29]

The two-natures framework enabled classical Christianity to say that the same person is omniscient as God yet limited in human knowledge, impassible in divinity yet suffering in humanity, and equal to the Father in divine nature yet obedient in the incarnate economy. Augustine and later Western theology further elaborated the unity and equality of the three persons, while medieval theology refined the metaphysical vocabulary.[9] [10]

10.7 Historical Assessment

The historical evidence supports two conclusions at once. First, the New Testament and earliest Christian worship contain genuine impulses toward very high Christology; Nicene theology did not answer a problem invented in the fourth century. Second, the precise doctrine of one essence in three coequal persons and one Christ in two natures emerged through development, debate, philosophical clarification, and ecclesial decision.

Whether that development represents faithful doctrinal maturation or an unnecessary metaphysical reinterpretation is a theological judgment, not a fact established merely by chronology. The most careful Unitarian critique is therefore not that Constantine invented Christ's divinity, but that biblical categories of agency, Wisdom, image, sonship, and exaltation were progressively recast through ontological categories that may not be required by their original contexts.

11. Nontrinitarian Trajectories — Jewish Christianity, Arianism, Socinianism, and Beyond

11.1 The Problem of Retrospective Labels

"Nontrinitarian" covers positions that differ radically from one another. A human-only Messiah, an adopted Son, a preexistent created Logos, a modal manifestation of one divine person, and a modern Biblical Unitarian account are not the same theology. Historical labels were often supplied by opponents, and much evidence for early minority groups comes through polemical heresiological reports. No responsible history should collapse all dissent from Nicaea into one continuous movement.

The historical existence of alternative Christologies shows that early Christian interpretation was diverse. It does not by itself prove that any later group preserves an unbroken apostolic succession of doctrine. Conversely, the victory of the Nicene position within imperial Christianity does not by itself prove that every element of the victorious synthesis was the original meaning of the biblical texts.

11.2 Jewish-Christian Groups

Writers such as Irenaeus, Origen, and Epiphanius describe groups later called Ebionites as Torah-observant Jewish Christians who regarded Jesus as Messiah while denying or qualifying personal preexistence. Reports differ over whether all such groups denied the virgin birth, and scholars debate the relation among Ebionites, Nazarenes, and the various Jewish-Christian gospels.[33]

These communities demonstrate that human-Messiah Christologies existed early. Their exact continuity with the first Jerusalem believers remains difficult to reconstruct, because the evidence is late, partial, and filtered through controversy. They should neither be dismissed as historically irrelevant nor romanticized as a transparent window into pristine apostolic belief.

11.3 Dynamic Monarchian and "Adoptionist" Currents

Theodotus of Byzantium and Paul of Samosata are commonly associated with forms of dynamic monarchianism in which the one God empowers, indwells, or elevates the human Jesus. Traditional histories often group such views under "adoptionism." Recent scholarship has cautioned that the category can oversimplify diverse positions and may impose later doctrinal questions upon fragmentary evidence.[34]

Even with that caution, these controversies show that some Christians interpreted divine sonship primarily through election, empowerment, moral obedience, baptism, resurrection, or exaltation rather than eternal generation. The proto-orthodox church rejected these explanations as inadequate to the scriptural and devotional status of Christ.

11.4 Arianism Is Not Biblical Unitarianism

Arianism belongs in a separate category. Arius affirmed a conscious preexistent Son who existed before the cosmos and served as God's agent in creation. The Son was not the supreme God, but neither was he merely the historical human Messiah. Modern Biblical Unitarians who deny personal preexistence therefore share Arius's rejection of Nicene coequality but reject his heavenly-creature Christology.

This distinction matters because the alternatives are not simply "Nicene Trinity" or "human Messiah." The early centuries included a range of mediating proposals: subordinate divine Logos, created heavenly Son, modalism, adoptionist or empowerment models, and developing pro-Nicene accounts.

11.5 Socinianism and the Racovian Catechism

The Reformation reopened questions that medieval ecclesial authority had largely closed. The Polish Brethren and Socinian movement rejected the Trinity, denied the personal preexistence of Christ, emphasized the Father as the one God, and interpreted Jesus as the miraculously conceived human Messiah whom God exalted. The *Racovian Catechism* gave systematic expression to this theology and to a Scripture-centered critique of inherited creeds.[32]

Socinianism also placed unusual weight on reason, moral transformation, religious toleration, and the prophetic role of Christ. It became an important forerunner of later Unitarian traditions, although modern Biblical Unitarians do not necessarily accept every Socinian doctrine of atonement, anthropology, or worship.[35]

11.6 Later and Modern Expressions

English figures such as John Biddle argued from Scripture for the Father's sole deity. Transylvanian Unitarianism preserved a distinct ecclesial tradition, while later English and American Unitarianism increasingly diversified and in many settings moved away from classical Christian supernaturalism. This development eventually made "Biblical Unitarian" useful as a designation for conservative, resurrection-affirming Christians who wished to distinguish themselves from liberal Unitarian or Unitarian Universalist traditions.

Later conservative expressions have appeared in several Bible-centered denominations, conferences, and independent fellowships. These communities vary on the virgin birth, the devil, atonement, the intermediate state, worship of Jesus, and ecclesiology. What unites them at the Christological level is the confession of the Father as the one God and Jesus as the human Messiah rather than a coequal divine person.

11.7 The Historical Argument Properly Stated

History cannot establish Biblical Unitarianism simply by locating early dissenters, nor can catholic prevalence establish Trinitarianism simply by showing that it became dominant. The historical question is more modest: which conceptual patterns are early, how were they transformed, and what pressures produced later formulas?

The evidence shows early high devotion, early human-Messiah alternatives, widespread Logos and Wisdom Christology, substantial subordination among pre-Nicene theologians, and a fourth-century movement toward coequal ontology. That complex record supports neither a triumphalist straight line nor a simple corruption narrative. It does support returning to the biblical texts and testing later syntheses rather than treating their historical dominance as self-validating.

12. God-Man or God's Man? — Comparing the Explanatory Models

12.1 The Strongest Trinitarian Case

The strongest Trinitarian argument is cumulative. It does not rest only on disputed translations of isolated verses. It observes that:

1. John identifies the preexistent Word with God and creation.
2. Jesus speaks of glory with the Father before the world and of existence before Abraham.
3. Paul and Hebrews place Christ in cosmic creation.
4. New Testament writers apply YHWH passages to Jesus.
5. Thomas and perhaps Paul, Titus, and 2 Peter call Jesus God.
6. Jesus receives an unparalleled place in worship, invocation, confession, judgment, and universal sovereignty.
7. First Corinthians 8:6 may include Jesus within the Shema itself.

Taken together, this is a formidable case. The Trinitarian model explains the highest texts by taking their apparent divine implications ontologically. It then explains dependence, limited knowledge, prayer, suffering, death, and subjection through incarnation, two natures, and distinctions between eternal equality and economic role.

Its principal exegetical cost is that these metaphysical distinctions are often not stated in the passages where they are needed. "The Son does not know" becomes "the Son does not know according to his human nature"; "my God" is assigned to the incarnate economy; and received authority coexists with intrinsic omnipotence. These explanations may be valid theological synthesis, but they are additional interpretive machinery.

12.2 The Strongest Biblical Unitarian Case

The strongest Biblical Unitarian argument also proceeds cumulatively:

1. The Father is explicitly called the only true God and the one God.
2. Jesus is repeatedly distinguished as Messiah, Son, Lord, mediator, servant, and man.
3. God performs works through Jesus, anoints him, raises him, exalts him, gives him authority, and appoints him judge.
4. Jesus prays to God, obeys God, calls the Father his God, and remains subject to God in the final order.
5. Scripture contains established categories of agents bearing divine names, words, functions, and throne-language.
6. Wisdom and Word traditions permit cosmic and revelatory language without automatically producing a second coequal person.
7. Royal, Adamic, prophetic, priestly, and Son of Man categories explain Jesus' exalted human vocation.

This model takes relational statements in their most immediate sense. Jesus is not the God who sends him; he is the uniquely authorized Messiah through whom God acts. His humanity is not one nature alongside an omniscient divine consciousness but the integral reality of his obedient life, temptation, faith, death, and resurrection.

Its principal cost is the burden placed on agency, Wisdom embodiment, and foreordination to explain the highest texts. John 17:5, Colossians 1, Hebrews 1:10–12, YHWH transfers, direct divine titles, and early devotion may seem to exceed what representation normally explains. The model is strongest when it concedes this pressure rather than treating every passage as simple.

12.3 Comparative Matrix

Criterion	Trinitarian explanatory strength	Biblical Unitarian explanatory strength
Explicit identification of the one God	Includes the Son through nature/person or divine-identity distinctions	Reads "one God, the Father" in its immediate personal sense
Jesus' prayer, obedience, limited knowledge, and "my God" language	Explained through incarnation, two natures, and economic relations	Read as ordinary relations between Messiah and God
Personal-preexistence texts	Strong, straightforward fit	Requires ideal, prophetic, foreordained, or Wisdom-embodiment readings
Creation language	Strong fit with the preexistent divine Son	Explained through Wisdom, Word, agency, cosmic messianic dominion, or retrospective predication
YHWH texts and divine titles	Strong evidence for inclusion in divine identity	Explained through name-bearing, royal representation, and scriptural transfer
Early devotion to Jesus	Strong evidence for inclusion in divine worship	Explained as God-authorized devotion to the exalted Messiah
The Holy Spirit and triadic formulas	Naturally integrated as the third divine person	Read as God's active presence within a triadic saving economy
Genuine humanity and Adamic obedience	Preserved through the two-natures doctrine	Constitutive of the model without an added nature distinction
Mediation and atonement	The divine-human Son unites humanity to God	God saves through the faithful human representative he appoints
Historical relation to Nicene doctrine	Sees legitimate doctrinal development	Sees a later metaphysical synthesis not demanded by the texts
Historical diversity	Interprets the proto-orthodox trajectory as the faithful mainstream	Emphasizes early alternatives and subordination before the Nicene settlement
Conceptual economy	Unifies the highest texts but uses complex metaphysics	Preserves relational grammar but bears the hardest cosmic and devotional texts

12.4 The Decisive Distinction

The deepest logical issue is the difference between **ontological identity** and **functional or representational identity**. Scripture can predicate the sender's words, authority, throne, judgment, saving work, titles, and name of an agent. None of those predications automatically answers the ontological question.

Conversely, representation cannot be invoked as a universal solvent. If the total pattern includes personal preexistence, intrinsic participation in creation, unique divine worship, and direct identification within the divine name, then agency alone may be insufficient. The interpreter must decide whether the New Testament crosses that line or stretches representation to its highest possible form.

12.5 Overall Judgment

On historical-grammatical grounds, the Biblical Unitarian model retains an advantage of explanatory economy for the New Testament's explicit relational architecture. One person calls another "my God," identifies him as "the only true God," is sent and commanded by him, receives authority from him, is raised and exalted by him, mediates between him and humanity, and is finally subjected to him. The natural conclusion is a distinction between the one God and **God's Man**—the Messiah whom that God appoints.

The Trinitarian model can accommodate all of this, but usually by invoking a distinction between person and nature, eternal and economic relations, or divine and human consciousness. Those distinctions may be theologically legitimate; they are not ordinarily supplied by the individual sentences themselves.

The judgment must remain qualified. The Biblical Unitarian reading does not remove every difficulty, and the highest Christological texts exert real pressure toward personal preexistence and divine identity. The conclusion is therefore a reasoned comparative judgment, not a claim that alternative readings are linguistically impossible.

13. Gospel and Faith Practice — Worship, Discipleship, and Proclamation

13.1 The Gospel's Narrative Shape

The gospel announces that the God of Israel has fulfilled his promises through Jesus the Messiah. Jesus proclaims the kingdom, embodies God's righteousness and compassion, dies for sins, is raised from the dead, receives universal lordship, pours out the Spirit, and will return to judge and renew the world. The saving movement is from the Father, through the Son, by the Spirit.

This proclamation does not make Christ secondary in practical importance. Jesus is the indispensable mediator, the risen Lord to whom allegiance is owed, the one through whom forgiveness and resurrection are given, and the appointed ruler of the coming age. Biblical Unitarianism seeks to place every honor within the relational order the New Testament repeatedly states: God is the source, Christ is the supreme mediator, and the Spirit is God's active presence.

13.2 Prayer, Worship, and Honor

Jesus teaches his disciples to pray to the Father, and much New Testament prayer follows the pattern of addressing God through Christ. A Biblical Unitarian spirituality therefore ordinarily centers worship upon the Father while confessing, obeying, thanking, invoking, and honoring Jesus as Lord. Honoring the Son honors the Father who sent and exalted him.

The New Testament also contains direct appeals to Jesus and exceptionally elevated praise of the Lamb. Biblical Unitarians differ over how frequently prayer should be directed to Jesus and whether some forms of homage should be called worship. The essential distinction is between honoring Jesus as the divinely appointed Lord and identifying him as the one God. Trinitarians reject that separation because they understand the Son as sharing the divine nature and therefore as a proper object of worship.

13.3 Discipleship and the Meaning of Jesus' Example

A genuinely human Messiah makes Jesus' obedience directly paradigmatic. His temptations are real, his trust in God is meaningful, his prayers are not a dramatic performance, and his suffering faithfulness displays what Spirit-filled humanity can become. Discipleship means following the human Son who trusted God perfectly, not merely admiring a divine being whose moral victory was guaranteed by intrinsic deity.

Trinitarian theology also insists that Jesus is fully human and truly tempted. The practical difference concerns how the two-natures framework is understood. Biblical Unitarians regard Jesus' single human consciousness and dependence upon God as central to his example; Trinitarians regard the incarnation as enabling the eternal Son to live a genuinely human life without ceasing to be divine.

13.4 Proclamation and Catechesis

The apostolic speeches in Acts foreground the kingdom, Jesus' messianic identity, crucifixion, resurrection, exaltation, forgiveness, the gift of the Spirit, and coming judgment. A Biblical Unitarian proclamation begins with this narrative rather than requiring converts first to master metaphysical terminology concerning essence and person.

That simplicity should not become anti-intellectualism. John, Paul, Hebrews, and Revelation demand serious engagement with preexistence, creation, divine titles, and worship. Effective teaching therefore combines the clear apostolic story with honest treatment of the highest Christological texts.

13.5 Christian Character in Disagreement

Because the identity of Jesus touches worship and salvation, disagreement easily becomes accusatory. Trinitarians may assume that Unitarians merely diminish Christ; Unitarians may assume that Trinitarians knowingly worship a second God. Both descriptions fail to represent the strongest forms of the opposing position.

Constructive dialogue requires precise definitions, willingness to concede difficult evidence, refusal to confuse every non-Nicene view with every other, and recognition that doctrinal seriousness does not justify caricature. The purpose of comparison is not to make the disagreement trivial, but to make it truthful.

14. Contemporary Implications — Theology, Fellowship, and Interfaith Dialogue

14.1 Intra-Christian Identity and Fellowship

The Nicene and Chalcedonian formulas remain foundational for Roman Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, and most Protestant churches. Biblical Unitarians therefore stand outside the doctrinal boundaries by which much historic Christianity defines orthodoxy. The disagreement affects baptismal recognition, church membership, ministry, hymnody, prayer, and the question of whether a nontrinitarian confession should be considered Christian.

Historical awareness can improve the tone without erasing the boundary. The doctrine developed because Christians were trying to protect monotheism, salvation, Jesus' divine significance, and his genuine humanity. Biblical Unitarians likewise seek to honor Scripture, the resurrection, the lordship of Christ, and the one God. Recognizing those intentions permits more exact disagreement than the labels "paganism," "idolatry," "cult," or "mere rationalism."

14.2 Scripture, Tradition, and Doctrinal Development

The debate exposes a central hermeneutical question: when is a later synthesis a legitimate implication of Scripture, and when does it become an imported framework? Trinitarians argue that the church required nonbiblical terms such as *ousia* and *hypostasis* to defend the biblical truth against distortions. Biblical Unitarianism answers that a doctrine made essential to faith should be stated more directly by the apostolic texts and should not depend upon metaphysical distinctions those texts do not supply.

The issue cannot be resolved by saying only that a word is absent from Scripture. Many valid doctrines use later terminology. Nor can it be resolved by appealing only to ecclesial antiquity. The proper test is whether the later formula explains the whole scriptural pattern more faithfully than the available alternatives.

14.3 Christian-Jewish Dialogue

A Father-centered Unitarian confession shares with Judaism an unqualified affirmation that the God of Israel is one person. Presenting Jesus as Messiah, prophet like Moses, Davidic king, Son of Man, and supreme *shaliah* removes the immediate claim that a human being must be identified with YHWH. This can make the Christian message more intelligible within Jewish monotheistic categories.

Substantial differences remain. Judaism does not generally confess Jesus as Messiah, resurrected Lord, universal judge, mediator of the new covenant, or the one through whom the nations receive eschatological life. Historical Christian persecution also cannot be reduced to a Christological misunderstanding. Biblical Unitarianism may remove one conceptual barrier, but it does not erase the distinctively Christian claims about Jesus.

14.4 Christian-Muslim Dialogue

Islam likewise rejects a tri-personal understanding of God and honors Jesus as Messiah and prophet while denying central Christian claims concerning divine sonship, crucifixion, resurrection, and redemptive lordship. A Biblical Unitarian can affirm without qualification that God is one person and that Jesus is not God, which removes the standard Muslim objection to the Trinity.

The remaining disagreement is still profound. Biblical Unitarians confess Jesus' unique sonship, death, resurrection, heavenly exaltation, future judgment, and binding lordship. Their position is therefore not an Islamic Christology expressed in Christian vocabulary. It offers a different form of Christian monotheism, not a dissolution of the Christian gospel into generic Abrahamic agreement.

14.5 Interfaith Usefulness Is Not the Test of Truth

A doctrine should not be accepted merely because it makes dialogue easier. Jewish or Muslim comprehensibility may show that a model preserves recognizable monotheistic categories, but it cannot decide the exegesis of John 1, Philippians 2, Colossians 1, Hebrews 1, or Revelation. Conversely, the difficulty of a doctrine does not prove its profundity or truth.

The proper value of interfaith dialogue is diagnostic. It forces Christians to state clearly whether they worship one God, what they mean by Son of God, how Jesus mediates divine action, and why honor given to Christ does or does not compromise monotheism. Clarity in those questions benefits both theological inquiry and respectful witness.

15. Conclusion — God's Man: Son, Messiah, and Lord

The New Testament Jesus is not merely a moral teacher or one prophet among many. He is **God's Man in the fullest biblical sense**: God's uniquely begotten Son, the Davidic Messiah, the last Adam, the embodiment of divine Wisdom, the image of the invisible God, the definitive revealer, the mediator of the new covenant, the resurrected Son of Man, the appointed judge, and the Lord of the coming age.

His greatness is relational and vocational. God sends him; he perfectly represents the sender. God gives him words; he speaks them faithfully. God gives him works; he performs them. God raises him; he becomes the firstfruits of renewed humanity. God exalts him; he receives the name and authority above every created ruler. God judges and saves through him; humanity comes to the Father through the Son.

This structure allows the highest possible honor for Jesus without dissolving the distinction between God and **God's Man**—**the Messiah he has appointed**. To see Jesus is to see the Father's character manifested. To receive Jesus is to receive the one who sent him. To honor the Son is to honor the Father who appointed him. Representation is not diminishment; in the biblical story it is the means by which the invisible God becomes known and active in history.

The Trinitarian synthesis remains a serious and historically sophisticated attempt to explain the same evidence. It should not be dismissed through slogans about Constantine, paganism, or logical absurdity. Its strongest texts and arguments must be granted their full weight. Yet the later formula of one essence in three coequal persons is a theological construction drawn from the New Testament, not a sentence the New Testament itself recites.

The most economical synthesis is therefore that the Father is the one God and Jesus is **God's Man—the one Lord Messiah** through whom the Father's purposes are accomplished. The eternal reality is God's Wisdom, Word, promise, and redemptive purpose; the historical embodiment and fulfillment is Jesus of Nazareth. The authority is God's; the authorized ruler is the Son. The saving action originates from God and reaches humanity through the Messiah.

This conclusion preserves the apostolic gospel's narrative shape. God acted through Jesus. Jesus proclaimed God's kingdom, obeyed faithfully, suffered, died, and was raised. God made him Lord and Messiah, seated him at the divine right hand, and appointed him judge. Through him God grants forgiveness, the Spirit, resurrection, and life in the coming age.

The same relational order includes the Spirit. God anoints and empowers Jesus by the Spirit, pours out the Spirit through the exalted Messiah, and dwells in believers by the Spirit. The triadic shape of salvation is fully real without requiring that Father, Son, and Spirit be defined as three coequal centers of personhood within one essence.

The final confession can therefore remain both monotheistic and christologically exalted: there is one God, the Father, and one Lord, Jesus Christ. The Father is the ultimate source; the Son is the supreme mediator. The image reveals the invisible God without becoming the one imaged. The Messiah exercises divine authority because God has entrusted it to him. The distinction between God and **God's Man** is not an embarrassment to be erased; it is the relational structure through which the New Testament tells the story of salvation.

The governing contrast can therefore be stated without ambiguity. The New Testament's dominant relational pattern is not God becoming his own human agent, but God acting uniquely and definitively through **God's Man**—the human Messiah whom he sent, empowered, raised, and exalted. "God's Man" does not mean *merely* a man. It identifies the man whom God made Lord and Messiah: the perfect image of God, the mediator of the new covenant, the firstborn from the dead, and the universal ruler of the coming age.

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